

Global Logistics Operating Handbook & Policy Manual

Northwind Freight Group — Operations Standard, Revision 4.1

1 Purpose and Scope

This handbook defines the mandatory operating standard for all Northwind Freight Group terminals, dispatch centres, and contracted carrier partners. It applies to every shipment moving under a Northwind booking reference, regardless of mode, origin, or customer contract tier.

Where a customer's master service agreement imposes a stricter requirement than this handbook, the customer agreement prevails and the terminal manager must record the deviation in the shipment file. Where a customer agreement is silent, this handbook is the controlling document.

1.1 Document Control

This handbook is revised twice yearly. The Operations Standards Committee owns the content; the Quality Assurance function owns distribution. Superseded revisions must be withdrawn from terminal noticeboards within ten working days of a new release.

Local work instructions may expand on this handbook but may never relax a control defined in it. Any proposed relaxation requires written approval from the Director of Operations.

1.2 Definitions

"On-duty dispatcher" means the named individual holding the dispatch roster slot at the time an event occurs, including weekend and public holiday slots. "Terminal" means any Northwind-operated or Northwind-leased facility where freight is received, held, or transferred. "Contracted carrier" means a third-party haulier operating under a Northwind carrier agreement.

"Cold-chain cargo" means any consignment booked with a contracted temperature set point, including chilled, frozen, and controlled ambient goods. "Set point" is the target temperature stated on the booking; "deviation" is any measured departure from that set point.

2 Roles and Responsibilities

Accountability for a shipment transfers with physical custody, but escalation duties do not. The originating dispatch centre retains escalation ownership for the full transit, even after the freight has left its region.

2.1 On-Duty Dispatcher

The on-duty dispatcher monitors active shipments, acknowledges telematics and sensor alarms, and initiates the escalation paths in Section 4 and Section 7. The dispatcher may not close an alarm without either resolving it or handing it to a named owner.

Dispatchers work a continuous roster. Handover at shift change requires a written handover note listing every open alarm, its age, and its assigned owner. An open alarm may never be handed over verbally.

2.2 Terminal Operations Supervisor

The terminal operations supervisor controls physical movement of freight within the facility, including hold decisions. When a consignment is placed on hold under Section 4, the supervisor is responsible for physically segregating it and applying a hold tag bearing the shipment reference and the time of the hold.

2.3 Cold-Chain Quality Lead

The cold-chain quality lead is the sole authority permitted to release temperature-deviated cargo for onward movement or to authorise disposal. There is a named primary and a named deputy for every region, and one of the two is on call at all times including weekends.

The quality lead reviews all Form CC-12 submissions within one working day and records a disposition decision against each one.

3 Freight Handling

All freight must be received against a booking reference. Freight arriving without a booking reference is quarantined in the unidentified freight bay and reported to the originating dispatch centre the same day.

3.1 Booking and Pre-Advice

Bookings close four hours before the scheduled terminal cut-off for domestic movements and twelve hours before cut-off for cross-border movements. Late bookings may be accepted only by the terminal operations supervisor and only where capacity is confirmed.

Cold-chain bookings must state the set point, the permitted tolerance band, and the sensor configuration. A cold-chain booking submitted without a stated set point is rejected automatically and returned to the customer for correction.

3.2 Documentation

Every consignment travels with a transport document, a packing list, and — where applicable — the customs declaration set. Documentation is checked at loading, not at booking, because contents frequently change between the two events.

Missing documentation is a loading stopper for cross-border freight and a recorded exception for domestic freight. Domestic freight may proceed with a recorded exception; cross-border freight may not proceed under any circumstance.

3.3 Loading and Securing

Load securing follows the regional load-restraint code applicable at the point of loading. Where origin and destination codes differ, the stricter of the two applies for the whole journey.

Mixed loads combining cold-chain and ambient freight in one compartment are prohibited unless the compartment is physically partitioned and separately sensed.

4 Cold-Chain and Perishable Cargo

Cold-chain freight is the highest-risk category Northwind handles, both commercially and in terms of product safety. The controls in this section are mandatory and may not be relaxed by local work instruction.

4.1 Pre-Cooling and Loading

Trailers and containers carrying cold-chain freight must be pre-cooled to the contracted set point and must hold that temperature for thirty minutes before loading begins. Pre-cooling is evidenced by the unit's own log, which is attached to the shipment file.

Loading a cold-chain consignment into a unit that has not achieved and held the set point is a reportable control failure, and the loading is stopped until a compliant unit is available.

4.2 Temperature Deviation and Weekend Escalation

A temperature deviation is any measured departure of more than 2°C from the contracted set point sustained for more than fifteen minutes. Deviations of 4°C or more are treated as temperature abuse and trigger the escalation below regardless of duration.

In the event of a weekend or public holiday temperature deviation exceeding 4°C above the contracted set point, the on-duty dispatcher must notify the cold-chain quality lead within two hours of the alarm being raised and must initiate Form CC-12 before the goods leave the terminal. The consignment is placed on hold and physically segregated pending the quality lead's disposition decision. Under no circumstance may temperature-abused perishable cargo continue to the consignee on a dispatcher's own authority.

Where the deviation is detected in transit rather than at a terminal, the vehicle is routed to the nearest Northwind facility or approved partner facility with cold storage, and the two-hour notification clock runs from the alarm, not from arrival.

Weekend escalation uses the on-call quality lead rota published in Appendix B. If the primary on-call lead cannot be reached within thirty minutes, the dispatcher escalates to the deputy, and then to the Director of Operations. An unanswered escalation is never a reason to release cargo.

4.3 Form CC-12 Cold-Chain Incident Record

Form CC-12 is the controlled record for every temperature deviation. It captures the shipment reference, the set point, the measured peak deviation, the duration, the sensor identifier, the time the alarm was raised, the time the quality lead was notified, and the physical location of the goods at the time of the hold.

The form must be initiated by the dispatcher who acknowledged the alarm and completed within four hours. An incomplete CC-12 blocks invoicing of the affected consignment.

4.4 Disposition of Deviated Cargo

The cold-chain quality lead selects one of four dispositions: release to consignee, release with customer notification and concession, return to shipper, or controlled disposal. Disposal requires a witnessed disposal certificate signed by two Northwind employees.

Cargo released with a concession must be accompanied by the CC-12 summary so the consignee can make their own acceptance decision. Concealing a deviation from a consignee is a disciplinary matter.

5 Carrier Performance, Claims and Credits

Carrier performance is measured monthly and reviewed quarterly with each contracted carrier. Persistent underperformance triggers the remediation ladder in Section 5.1.

5.1 On-Time In-Full Measurement

On-time in-full (OTIF) is measured against the promised delivery window, not the carrier's own estimate. A delivery is on time if it arrives within the promised window; it is in full if the delivered quantity matches the transport document without shortage or damage.

A carrier falling below 94 per cent OTIF in two consecutive months enters a documented improvement plan. A carrier falling below 88 per cent in any single month is suspended from new bookings until the improvement plan is agreed.

5.2 Damage and Loss Claims

Claims for visible damage must be noted on the delivery receipt at the point of delivery. Claims for concealed damage must be raised within seven calendar days of delivery for domestic movements and within fourteen calendar days for international movements.

Northwind acknowledges a claim within three working days and issues a determination within twenty working days of receiving complete supporting evidence. Incomplete claims are held, and the determination clock does not start until the file is complete.

5.3 Refunds and Service Credits

Where Northwind has failed a contracted service level, the customer is entitled to a service credit against the freight charge for the affected consignment. Service credits are applied to the next invoice rather than refunded to source, unless the customer account is closing.

The refund window for international customers is thirty calendar days from the invoice date, extended to sixty calendar days where a customs authority hold caused the delay. Domestic customers have a fourteen-calendar-day refund window. Requests received outside the window are handled as goodwill claims and require commercial approval.

6 Hazardous and Restricted Goods

Northwind accepts limited classes of dangerous goods only at nominated terminals with trained staff and current facility approvals. Acceptance is by exception, never by default.

6.1 Acceptance Screening

Every booking is screened against the restricted commodity list at submission. Flagged bookings are routed to the dangerous goods safety adviser, who either approves the movement with conditions or rejects it.

Undeclared dangerous goods discovered in a consignment are isolated immediately, the shipper is notified, and the incident is reported to the safety adviser the same day.

6.2 Segregation in Storage

Segregation distances follow the applicable modal dangerous goods code. Where a terminal cannot achieve the required segregation, the consignment is refused rather than stored non-compliantly.

7 Customer Communication Standards

Customers are told about problems by Northwind, not by their consignee. Proactive notification is the standard, and the timings below are contractual minimums.

7.1 Notification Timings

A delay expected to exceed four hours is notified to the customer within one hour of it becoming known. A cold-chain deviation is notified within four hours of the alarm, in parallel with the internal escalation in Section 4.2. A loss is notified immediately upon confirmation.

First response to an inbound customer enquiry is within four working hours. Substantive resolution or a dated plan is provided within two working days.

7.2 Escalation Matrix

Tier one is the account coordinator. Tier two is the regional operations manager, reached when an issue is unresolved after two working days or where the value at risk exceeds twenty-five thousand euro. Tier three is the Director of Operations, reached for any product safety issue, any regulatory notification, or any issue affecting more than five customers simultaneously.

Appendix A — Controlled Forms Register

CC-12 Cold-Chain Incident Record. CL-04 Damage and Loss Claim. DG-02 Dangerous Goods Acceptance Condition Sheet. HO-07 Shipment Hold Tag. HV-01 Shift Handover Note. DS-03 Witnessed Disposal Certificate.

Controlled forms are issued only from the document management system. Locally recreated versions of a controlled form are invalid and must not be used in a shipment file.

Appendix B — On-Call Escalation Rota

The cold-chain on-call rota names a primary and deputy quality lead per region for every calendar week, including public holidays. The rota is published two weeks in advance and republished within one hour of any change.

Dispatchers must use the current published rota rather than stored personal contact details. Using a superseded contact does not satisfy the notification requirement in Section 4.2.